

Jiancai (Johnson) Liao

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Employment

Assistant Professor of Marketing, University of Birmingham, 2025 – present

Education

Ph.D., Marketing, Aalto University School of Business, Finland, 2025
M.Sc., Marketing, Sun Yat-sen University, China, 2020
B.Sc., Marketing, Chongqing University, China, 2017

Research Interests

Theoretical: Consumer Wellbeing, Self-Care, Identity-Based Motivation, Human-AI Interaction

Substantive: Healthcare Services, Digital Health Platforms, AI in Services, Health Adherence

Methodological: Lab and Field Experiments, Causal Inference (DiD, Causal Forests), Meta-Analysis, Text Mining

Visiting Positions

Visiting Scholar, SCANCOR, Stanford University, USA, 2025–2026

Visiting PhD Researcher, Virginia Tech, USA, 2025

Visiting PhD Researcher, City University of Hong Kong, China, 2023–2024

Publications

1. **Liao, J.**, Zhou, S., & Kang, Q. (2026). Externalizing the mental struggle: How anthropomorphism enhances health engagement. *Psychology & Marketing*.
2. Huang, J., **Liao, J.**[†] & Xia, C. (2026). How guilt influences consumer response to anthropomorphized brands. *Journal of Product & Brand Management*.
3. Huang, J., & **Liao, J.**[†] (2026). The negative influence of robot replicates on human-robot rapport. *Journal of Hospitality Marketing & Management*.
4. Lv, L., Zhang, Y., **Liao, J.**, Chen, J., & Dai, G. (2026). How personalized recommendations influence customers' sustainable hotel booking. *International Journal of Hospitality Management*.
5. Tao, J., Liu, G.G., Yu, J.J. & **Liao, J.** (2026). How social media sharing motivations transform tourist-destination relationships. *Journal of Sustainable Tourism*.
6. Lv, L., Liang, Y., Chen, S., Liu, G.G., & **Liao, J.** (2025). Leveraging generative AI to reduce tourists' avoidance of ethical brands. *Annals of Tourism Research*.
7. Cheng, L., Zhang, J., **Liao, J.**, Peng, F., & Wang, X. (2025). Dehumanization and aggression: A meta-analysis. *Aggression and Violent Behavior*.
8. **Liao, J.** & Huang, J. (2024). Think like a robot: How interactions with humanoid service robots affect consumers. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services*.
9. Shen, M., **Liao, J.**, & Wang, H. (2024). Analysis of consumer medication adherence: Based on two-stage theoretical model. *Advances in Psychological Science*.
10. Rahim, A., Wang, H., **Liao, J.**, & Khan, S. (2023). Does dignity matter? A study of donors' behavior. *Current Psychology*.
11. **Liao, J.**, Huang, J., & Su, L. (2022). When and how virus anthropomorphism intensifies consumer stigma toward patients. *Advances in Consumer Research*.

Papers Under Review

1. **Liao, J.**, Liu, C., Ni, J., & Wang, H. The paradox of access: How increased generic drug availability affects patient adherence. *Journal of Marketing Research*.
2. **Liao, J.**, Klein, J. F., Falk, T., Sundqvist, S., & Paasonen, P. Advice adherence in professional services: A meta-analysis. *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science*.
3. **Liao, J.**, Liang, Y., Lin, Y., & Lv, L. Overcoming uniqueness neglect: How AI disclosure structure shapes service evaluation. *Journal of Service Research*.
4. Xie, H. & **Liao, J.** How hierarchical team appointments reshape patient flow and healthcare resource utilization. *Production and Operations Management*.
5. Shen, M., **Liao, J.**[†] & Song, Y. The power of tolerance for contradiction: Improving consumer health adherence. *European Journal of Marketing*.
6. Zhou, S., Kang, Q., & **Liao, J.** Taking selfies increases preference for self-improvement products. *Psychology & Marketing*.

Selected Working Papers

1. **Liao, J.**, Zhang, L., & Chen, H. Family role salience increases consumers' self-care behavior. Target: *Journal of Consumer Psychology*.
2. **Liao, J.**, & Xie, H. When do pay-after-use interventions alleviate poverty traps? Evidence from China's Treat-First-Pay-Later policy. Target: *Management Science*.
3. Huang, S., **Liao, J.**[†], & Zhang, Y. Physician multihoming and healthcare resource allocation: An analytical model with causal evidence. Target: *Information Systems Research*.

Selected Presentations

2026: EMAC (Bath, UK), CMAU (Dalian, China)

2025: ISMS Marketing Science (Washington DC), AMA Marketing and Public Policy (Washington DC)

2024: Association for Consumer Research (Paris), ISMS Marketing Science (Sydney), EMAC (Bucharest)

2023: China India Insights Conference (Stanford University), Asia Pacific Marketing Academy (Guangzhou)

Grants and Awards

Research Grants Received (as PI): €154,600+

Jenny and Antti Wihuri Foundation Working Grant, €60,000, 2023–2025

Marcus Wallenberg Foundation Working Grant, €37,000, 2022–2025

HSE Support Foundation Research Grant, €40,000+, 2021–2025

Awards: EMAC Doctoral Consortium Fellow (2024); Best Paper Award, Finnish Academy of Marketing (2022)

Teaching

University of Birmingham (2025–present): Marketing and New Technology (UG, Module Leader); Individual Company Project (PG, Module Leader)

Aalto University (2022–2025): Consumer Psychology (MSc, Sole Responsible Teacher, Spring 2024)

Service

Ad-hoc Reviewer: Journal of Consumer Behaviour, Journal of Consumer Marketing, EMAC, ACR

Professional Memberships: European Marketing Academy (EMAC), Academy of Marketing (AM), Association for Consumer Research (ACR)

[†] denotes co-first author